

Quantificational controls: attestations and provenance

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I SCOPE AND COMPARISON

This supplement records the independent quantificational uses discussed in §2.3 of *Determinatives as nouns in English*. It preserves the comparison table, retained attestations, and source-verification limits. The searches establish selected occurrences, without estimating their frequency or establishing an ordering of the constructions.

The Cambridge grammar of the English language (CGEL; Huddleston and Pullum, 2002) includes *several* among determinatives and treats quantificational *certain* and *various* as marginal members. The *of*-phrase with independent *certain* and *various* is hardly omissible. The partitive with *certain* is relatively formal; that with *various* is accepted by some speakers, primarily in American English (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 392–393, 411–413).

Table 1 separates NP dependents from the surrounding construction. The argument frames are *X of them*, *X who arrived left*, and anaphoric *X left*. The existential frames are *There are X of them*, *There are X who can help*, and anaphoric *Are there X?* Interpret the constructed comparisons with people under discussion. Argument use also includes complementation of prepositions. The common-noun controls retain *a* in *a lot*.

Table 1: Independent quantificational uses. G: described in CGEL; R: restricted there; I: constructed positive illustration in the stated frame. Numbered references identify attestations below. S: searched, with no qualifying attestation retained; this isn't an ungrammaticality judgment.

Expression	Argument use			Existential displaced subject		
	Partitive PP	Relative clause	No dependent	Partitive PP	Relative clause	No dependent
<i>many</i>	G	G	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>
<i>several</i>	G	<i>I</i>	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>
<i>certain</i>	G	S	R	(4a)	(3g)	S
<i>various</i>	G	(2a)	R	(4b)	S	S
<i>numerous</i>	(1b)	(2b)	(1d)	(4c)	(3f)	(4d)
<i>multiple</i>	(1c)	(2c)	(1e)	(3b)	(3d)	(3a)
<i>countless</i>	(1a)	(2d)	(2e)	(3c)	(3e)	(4e)
<i>plenty</i>	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>
<i>a lot</i>	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>

The G and R cells retain the qualifications just stated; the common-noun partitives follow *CGEL* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 349–350). The relative use of *many* follows *CGEL*’s discussion of the human interpretation (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 414). The attestations below combine targeted searches in NOW and COCA with separately located examples. Expanded contexts exclude overt following nouns, predicative inversions, and mathematical *multiple*. These searches establish selected occurrences; they supply no usage rates.¹

The examples in (1) show partitive and independent subject uses of further quantity words. The *countless* partitive comes from academic prose; the *multiple* partitive from a blog discussion. The final two examples have independent quantifiers as subjects, with people recoverable from context. Their occurrence requires a description even where speakers differ over their acceptability.

- (1) a. *countless of their particular statements and deeds*²
- b. *numerous of its inhabitants*³
- c. *multiple of the fast casual eateries*⁴
- d. *numerous were injured*⁵
- e. *multiple were injured*⁶

Relative postmodification extends the comparison in (2). The first four quantity words complement prepositions and have relative postmodifiers. The final *countless* is a subject without a dependent, with viewers supplied by the preceding clause.

- (2) a. *think about various who had done it and who hadn’t*⁷
- b. *he has heard from numerous who are “deeply concerned”*⁸
- c. *according to multiple who have spoken to him*⁹
- d. *paving the way for countless who followed him*¹⁰

¹ Searches conducted on 12–13 September 2026 in NOW and COCA, using surface strings without part-of-speech filters. Queries, retained excerpts, and verification limits are recorded in notes/2026-09-12-quantifier-controls-corpus.json; separate source checks are in notes/2026-09-12-quantifier-controls-sources.json. The fourteen-cell follow-up is recorded in notes/2026-09-13-quantifier-cells.json.

² Thomas Hughson, “Interpreting Vatican II: ‘A New Pentecost’”, *Theological Studies* 69 (2008), p. 9; COCA academic record, checked against the journal PDF. The NP is object of *irradiate*.

³ Norman Harrington, *New York Times*, 7 April 1968, as quoted in *Merriam-Webster’s Dictionary of English Usage* and reproduced in Reynolds and Pullum’s “New members of closed classes in English”, §2.1.2. Verified through that draft; the newspaper original wasn’t checked.

⁴ COCA, 2012 blog discussion under “BurgerFi Bringing Its Burgers to...”. The surrounding phrase is *in front of multiple of the fast casual eateries*. Expanded corpus context and source metadata checked; the original page wasn’t available.

⁵ Page Six, 4 July 2022; NOW expanded context. The clause follows a coordinated clause about people who died. Here *numerous* is the canonical subject.

⁶ Ivana Saric and Herb Scribner, *Axios*, 27 June 2022, opening sentence; original page checked.

⁷ Stephen Tompkinson, quoted by James Hibbs in *Radio Times*, 29 April 2026; NOW and original interview. The context concerns identifying killers in detective scripts; no audio check.

⁸ ABC News, 18 August 2020; NOW record dated 19 August and original article. The antecedent is Republican attorneys.

⁹ The London Free Press, NOW record dated 19 November 2018, on recruiting campaign staff; concordance and source metadata checked. The original page wasn’t available.

¹⁰ WFTV, NOW record dated 7 January 2022, on Sidney Poitier; concordance and source metadata checked. The original URL returned an error page.

- e. *countless were left in floods of tears*¹¹

Existentials show a further range in (3). In (3a), *multiple* ends the question, with wedding dresses under discussion. The next two examples contain partitives. The remaining examples have relative postmodifiers and include published prose, a hearing transcript, and reported speech. Source locations identify the records; they don't establish each speaker's or writer's variety.

- (3) a. *are there multiple?*¹²
 b. *there are multiple of them*¹³
 c. *There are countless of them out there*¹⁴
 d. *There are multiple that are cited in my response.*¹⁵
 e. *There are countless who have greatly impacted their communities*¹⁶
 f. *there are numerous who are willing to donate*¹⁷
 g. *there are certain who would not like ...*¹⁸

The additional existential examples in (4) supply partitives with *certain*, *various*, and *numerous*. The final two have no NP dependent: *numerous* refers to benefits of a college education and *countless* to investment options. These contexts establish anaphoric interpretations without an overt following nominal.

- (4) a. *There are certain of our friends.*¹⁹
 b. *There are various of Maro's own inventions*²⁰
 c. *There are numerous of them.*²¹
 d. *I'm aware there are numerous.*²²

¹¹John Murphy, *Extra.ie*, 17 April 2022; NOW and original article. The preceding clause mentions viewers of *DIY SOS*.

¹²Kira Bindrim, in a *Quartz podcast transcript*, 2022; NOW and original transcript. The preceding question introduces wedding dresses. NOW dates the record 22 February; the current page reports an update on 20 July.

¹³Ivan Mehta, *TechCrunch*, 16 September 2022; NOW and original article. The antecedent is objects in a photo.

¹⁴"Facebook's Future Is Brighter Than Ever", *Seeking Alpha*, 25 May 2020; NOW expanded context and source metadata. The antecedent is payment apps.

¹⁵Zachary Loyed, public-records hearing, *State of Florida v. Thomas Lee Gudinas*, 29 May 2025, transcript p. 7, lines 14–15; *Appendix C*, PDF p. 55. Original transcript checked; *multiple* refers to cases.

¹⁶"The Sisterhood List", *Metro*, 1 October 2023; NOW expanded context and source metadata.

¹⁷Nana Patekar, as quoted in English by IANS in *The Indian Express*, 19 September 2015; NOW and original article. The original language of the speech wasn't established.

¹⁸Donald Trump, as quoted in *Fox News*, 25 March 2020; NOW record dated 26 March and original article. The quotation was checked against the article, without an audio check.

¹⁹Sharad Pawar, quoted in English by Manish Tewari in *Deccan Chronicle*, 8 July 2018; NOW record dated 7 July and original article. The original speech language and audio weren't checked.

²⁰Erica Platter, *Daily Maverick*, 8 March 2019; NOW and original article. The context lists cakes, with supplementary examples following the partitive.

²¹Sunday Cyriacus Umeha, interviewed by Adamu Abuh in *The Guardian (Nigeria)*, 7 June 2025; NOW and original interview. The antecedent is people from Enugu appointed to government positions.

²²Danny Sapio, *The Next Web*, 15 December 2019; NOW record dated 29 December and original article, syndicated from uxdesign.cc.

e. *In fact, there are countless.*²³

No qualifying attestation was retained for four cells: argument *certain* with a relative, bare existential *certain*, and existential *various* with a relative or without a dependent. The bounded searches don't establish exclusion. These cells retain a different evidential status from the positive examples and from *CGEL*'s stated restrictions.

2 CHECKS OF STATED EXCLUSIONS

The article states several exclusions as starred examples. Each was checked against COCA on 17 September 2026 with the search strings in Table 2; the returned lines were screened by a typed-judgment model for the excluded structure and every line above the screen's floor was read. A zero or an unattested result is not an ungrammaticality judgment, and an attested structure is reported with its register. Two exclusions were restated in the article as a result; the lines, counts, and readings are preserved in the project repository under `corpus/exclusion_tests/`.

²³*Financial Post*, NOW record dated 3 August 2013; complete sentence and adjacent context checked in the concordance. The original page wasn't available.

Table 2: Corpus checks of exclusions stated in the article. Queries use English-Corpora.org syntax; [v*], [nn*], [nn2*], [j*] and [at*] are tag families, and / alternates single words. Hits are lines read unless marked List.

Exclusion	Query	Hits	Result; handling
Independent <i>every</i> (<i>*I'll take every</i>)	every [v*]	1,095 lines read	no ordinary fused-head use; <i>every</i> in ellipsis (<i>if not every, then almost every N</i>), reply fragments, and binomials (<i>any and every</i>); slips for <i>everyone</i> in informal text; claim kept for fused-head use
Degree adverb on a non-gradable determinative (<i>*very every, *very some, *very this</i>)	very every/some/this; so every/some/this	7 lines; 22,938 (List) for <i>so</i> , all discourse <i>so</i>	no qualifying line; two jocular cases (<i>very this, very this year</i>); holds
Reversed order (<i>*very a few, *a quite few</i>)	very a few; a quite few	0	unattested; holds
Attributive <i>*so numerous mistakes</i>	so numerous [nn*]; too numerous [nn*]	4 + 4	none for <i>so</i> ; three marginal web lines for <i>too</i> (<i>too numerous inaccuracies</i>); holds for <i>so</i>
Partitive <i>*no of the students</i>	no of the	0	unattested; holds
Compounds exclude an article and a pre-head adjective	[at*] [j*] someone/somebody/something; [at*] someone/somebody/something	496 + 494 lines; <i>special someone</i> 282, <i>certain someone</i> 120 (List)	attested at volume and productively (<i>an anonymous someone, a furry something, such an anyone</i>); restated as the set-denoting use (article §4.5)
Singular agreement with <i>each of the people</i>	each of them was/were/is/are/has/have (List); each of the [nn2*] was/were	389 singular, 78 plural; 151 <i>was</i> , 73 <i>were</i>	plural agreement in a sixth of tokens after <i>each of them</i> , in every register; restated with the rate (article §2.2)

REFERENCES

- Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2002). *The Cambridge grammar of the English language*. Cambridge University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316423530>